PLATE COMMENTARIES

A: 1947–48

A1: Soldier, 1 JAT, New Delhi, 1947

This sentry stands guard outside the vice-regal residence. The Jat Regiment traces its origins from the Calcutta Native Militia in 1795 and assumed its present form in January 1922, when one training and four active battalions were combined to form the Jat Regiment. After independence, it retained the regimental badge (**1a**), with 'IX' representing its ninth position in the regimental hierarchy of the Indian Army of the 1920s, though when India became a republic in 1950 the *ashoka* emblem replaced the crown. The insignia also has a bugle, indicating the Light Infantry antecedents of two of its battalions. Armed with a .303 SMLE bolt-action rifle with fixed bayonet, the soldier wears the olive-green cotton uniform and the regimental green beret. He wears Pattern 37 equipment and drill boots with anklets.

A2: PIAT gunner, 1 KUMAON (Para), Kashmir, 1948

This paratrooper wears the maroon beret with regimental badge (**2a**) and Denison smock indicative of his role with battledress serge trousers and standard Pattern 37 webbing. The PIAT (Projector, Infantry, Anti-Tank) offered useful close-range anti-tank firepower to the Indian Army's infantrymen, and could also be employed against enemy fortifications. Formed in 1813 and the Kumaon Regiment's oldest battalion, 1 KUMAON converted to an airborne role in 1946. During the First Kashmir War, the battalion was employed as part of 19 Independent Infantry Brigade in the recapture of Jhangar and was later tasked with reinforcing and defending the threatened town of Poonch, which withstood a siege by Pakistani and tribal forces from November 1947 until relieved in November 1948.

A3: Jawan, 3 GARH RIF, Tithwal, 1948

Armed with a 9mm Mk II Sten SMG, this soldier wears the cap comforter, pullover jersey over olive-green uniform, ammunition boots and anklets. The battle of Tithwal, in which 3 GARH RIF played an important role, was one of the fiercest and longest battles fought during the First Kashmir War. Pashtun tribal militiamen had crossed the border and occupied the strategically important village of Tithwal, which was fought over and claimed by both sides on a number of occasions. On 13 October 1948, a massive attack was launched by the Pakistan Army in a bid to capture the posts held by Indian Army troops, but it failed with heavy casualties.

B: 1962

B1: Lance corporal, Corps of Military Police, Assam

The Chinese incursion south of the Thagla Ridge in Tawang sector in NEFA (Northeast Frontier Agency, now Arunachal Pradesh) spurred the Indian Army to move additional troops into the sector to try to hold the Chinese. The first formation to move up was 7 Infantry Brigade, with orders to 'Throw the Chinese Out.' With only one road axis from the plains of Assam to Tawang, it was a challenge to move the men and equipment on this axis. Here, a military policeman of IV Corps (**1a**) is depicted during traffic duties associated with the military convoys. Armed with a 9mm Mk II Sten SMG, he wears a scarlet beret; the shoulder titles on his olive-green cotton uniform denote his arm of service, while his rank is